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ADL, JFed, Hold Press Conference with Law Enforcement on Colleyville

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The Anti-Defamation League (ADL) and Jewish Federation (JFed) of Greater Los Angeles held a joint press conference with law enforcement on January 21 about the hostage crisis in Colleyville, TX on January 15.

ADL Los Angeles Regional Director Jeffrey I. Abrams said during the press conference that the hostage-taker, identified by law enforcement as 44-year-old Malik Faisal Akram, "took four Jewish men hostage" at "not just any building but a synagogue [Congregation Beth Israel]. Not just any day but Saturday, the Jewish Sabbath." Akram demanded that Pakistani neuroscientist Dr. Aafia Siddiqui be released from a federal prison in the Fort Worth area; Siddiqui is serving an 86-year sentence for attempting to kill United States soldiers and FBI agents in Afghanistan.

"This appears to be the sole reason why that synagogue in Texas was targeted that day," Abrams said, "because of a belief by the hostage-taker that if he took Jewish hostages, the rabbi could simply call another rabbi in New York––a rabbi the hostage-taker had seen with [former] President [Barack] Obama––and because of age-old antisemitic tropes about Jewish power and control of the government, [he] believed that somehow, that would result in the release of this person. As unhinged and unbelievable as that may sound, it's yet another example of the surge in antisemitism across our country––which ADL has been tracking––an antisemitism fueled by rhetoric and spread by unregulated and unapologetic social media companies."

He added the synagogue's rabbi, Charlie Cytron-Walker, cited his training with the ADL and JFed as the key to surviving the hostage crisis. Abrams also noted that the ADL and JFed have been advocating for more funding from the federal and state government to Jewish nonprofits for security, calling for the federal government to increase its funding from $180 million to $360 million. Abrams also applauded Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-San Fernando Valley), who chairs the California Legislative Jewish Caucus for introducing a bill extending nonprofit grants. Additionally, Abrams touted the ADL's partnership with law enforcement in "sharing information from ADL's Center on Extremism" and as well as "best practices and information about hate crimes."

Rabbi Noah Farkas, President and CEO of JFed of Greater Los Angeles, said that Jews only make up about 2% of the American population––noting that "there are more people that live between San Diego and Santa Barbara than there are Jews in the world"––but 60% of hate crimes in the U.S. are committed against Jews. He touted the Federation's Community Security Initiative, which he described as connecting all of the various Jewish institutions in Los Angeles to provide security training and partner with law enforcement to monitor for potential security threats. "Over the past weekend, our team was working in overtime to make sure that every Jewish individual... knew that we were there for them," Farkas said. He called for all nonprofit security grants––not just Jewish nonprofits––to be doubled or tripled "so they can have a safe and secure experience and live their lives like everyone else." Farkas added that providing security is a "very expensive proposition," pointing out that Congregation Beth Israel couldn't afford to have a security guard protecting the synagogue. In Los Angeles County, congregations have to spend "millions and millions of dollars" on security, Farkas said.

FBI Assistant Director in Charge of the Los Angeles Field Office Kristi Johnson then spoke, saying that the FBI considers the Colleyville hostage crisis as "an act of terror targeting the Jewish community" and are working "to determine why this individual targeted this specific synagogue on the Sabbath." She also encouraged the Jewish community to contact the FBI about any specific threats against the community. Amir Ehsaei, Special Agent In Charge of the Counterterrorism Division at the Los Angeles Field Office, said that the FBI has not found "a larger plot" targeting the Los Angeles area.

Other speakers included Los Angeles Police Department (LAPD) Assistant Police Chief Beatrice Girmala and Beverly Hills Police Chief Mark Steinbrook.

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